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DECENTRALIZATION AS POLITICAL STRATEGY IN WEST AFRICA

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Administrative and political decentralization have emerged as high developmental priorities in Africa and elsewhere. Although the possible benefits of such reforms have been well theorized, the actual politics of decentralization are not well understood. Often there are large gaps between reform rhetoric and governments' real commitment to decentralization. And often legal changes have not produced decentralization's supposed political and administrative benefits. These dynamics have been especially clear in rural Africa, where a decade of decentralizing reforms has produced generally disappointing results. When *do* regimes pursue state-building strategies that involve real devolution of political and administrative prerogative? This article addresses this question and proposes an answer for rural West Africa. The author employs a political economy approach to propose a model of regional variation in the political capacities and interests of rural societies and rural notables and argues that these differences shape the institution-building strategies governments choose trying to entrench their power.

Keywords: *decentralization, democratization, regionalism, Senegal, Côte d'Ivoire, Ghana*

Institutions linking state and countryside in Africa, as in virtually all developing countries, have formal mandates to promote development and national integration. They structure prices and other economic incentives, distribute political power and authority, and establish formal rules of the game to govern political process. Yet as political actors and analysts have long been aware, there is often acute disjuncture between the formal rules that define institutional structure and functions and the real politics of how

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government agencies and institutions work. International planners and financial agencies that advocate reforms that will “get the institutions right” have become increasingly sensitive to this fact: The effectiveness of reform is determined largely by broad features of the political-economic context in which reform is carried out.

This point is especially salient in rural Africa, where sweeping reform of the institutions structuring state-society relations and everyday economic life has come to be seen as the highest developmental priority. Yet here, as in Mexico, the Philippines, and elsewhere since the early 1990s, change in formal rule structures has not always produced the desired effects.¹ Decentralization has not necessarily empowered local citizens and can simply strengthen local power brokers or state agents instead. Freer markets can lead to cutbacks rather than new opportunities in export-crop production. Legalization of political opposition does not always protect a regime’s opponents from reprisals or broaden the local political arena. Broad institution-building mandates are interpreted and implemented in locally specific ways, often with geographically uneven and contradictory effects.

When do regimes pursue state-building strategies that involve real political and administrative decentralization? When do they reform state structures in order to devolve political and administrative prerogative to local actors? When does power sharing actually occur?

This article tackles these questions about decentralization. It argues that differences in the power and interests of rural social actors go far in determining the answers and offers a set of hypotheses for exploring these differences in rural African settings. Institutional reform in the African countryside is viewed not as a technical or administrative problem to be solved by the center but rather as a highly political process. It is shaped decisively by struggles within rural society and between rural interests and the state—and these political factors can vary a great deal across space.

I employ a political economy approach to propose a model of regional variation in the political capacities and interests of rural societies and rural notables and to argue that these differences shape the institution-building strategies governments choose trying to entrench their own power.

The model draws on insights from two literatures. The first is choice theoretic. Following North (1990), Levi (1988), and Knight (1992), institutional outcomes are viewed as the product of political bargaining and conflict between rulers and societal groups. The second is the macrosociological and microsociological literature on state formation in agrarian societies. Robert Brenner (1976, 1982), Hechter and Brustein (1980), Barrington Moore, Jr.

1. See, for example, Crook and Manor (1998).

(1966), Paige (1975), Scott (1975), and others have shown how the organization of rural society has shaped and constrained the gathering of state power in European, Latin American, and Asian states. These works offer hypotheses about sources of variation in rural interests and bargaining power and the implications of these differences for state-formation dynamics. Drawing on Geschiere (1984, 1986), I extend these hypotheses to West African contexts and advance arguments about how governments' institution-building strategies are shaped by the rural societies they seek to govern.

I focus on two eras of political negotiation over the design of state institutions in rural Africa. The first is the decolonization era (1950s to about 1975). The second is the era of democratic decentralization initiatives (1985 to the present). Throughout much of sub-Saharan Africa in the decolonization era, governments confronted peasant societies that differed in their political capacity to shape the terms of their integration into national political economies. New politicians in the cities found themselves locked in negotiations and confrontations with rural elites over the distribution of power, political prerogative and authority, and rural wealth. Rural elites, meanwhile, tried to protect power and authority already achieved and to wield power and influence over the ordinary farmers who were their followers, clients, kinsfolk, and subjects. The intensity and nature of the rural political challenge to new African regimes varied by region, shaping and constraining possibilities for conflict and collaboration between regimes and rural notables. In the current era, rulers are again attempting to reform state institutions in the countryside in ways that will help stabilize and shore up the center. Processes of managing, harnessing, circumventing, or trying to accommodate rural interests and social actors are in full evidence once again.

The material presented here suggests that even in Africa, where rural social structures are often taken to be exceptionally homogeneous across space, how and whether particular peasant societies can bargain with, constrain, or challenge those at the center has varied considerably. These variations are reflected in unevenness in real patterns of centralization and decentralization of state power.

Part I identifies a repertoire of institution-building strategies that regimes can employ in linking center and rural periphery. Strategies vary by the extent to which they produce spatial deconcentration of the state apparatus and the extent to which institutions work to devolve power (including political and administrative discretion) to local actors. Part II models differences in the interests and bargaining strength of rural elites. Part III advances an argument about how rural social structure and political dynamics shape governments' institutional choices in the African countryside. This reasoning is used to

explain variation in rural state-building trajectories from the 1950s through about 1975 (Part IV), and from about 1985 to the present (Part V) in three major zones of peasant-based export crop production in West Africa: Senegal's groundnut basin, southern Côte d'Ivoire, and southern Ghana.

I. INSTITUTION-BUILDING STRATEGIES

In arguing that institutions are created to vest the interests of the powerful, proponents of a positive theory of institutions are in perfect accord with most analysts of state-society relations in postcolonial Africa. Few observers of the early postcolonial years question the idea that rulers created state institutions that would entrench their power and enhance the state's extractive capacities. Power-consolidation strategies—originally conceived as means to higher ends—quickly became ends in themselves. State institutions in *rural* Africa seemed to exemplify the process. As Robert Bates (1991, p. 118) has argued, scholars on the political left and right of the old development debates gradually converged on the argument that “rural development” agencies in much of sub-Saharan Africa could be understood as institutions of rural political control and taxation. Anthropologist Pierre-Yves le Meur (1998, p. 58) put it this way: “When it comes to development, in particular . . . in the case of policies undertaken by the state, the explicit economic objective (extraction of surplus) is inseparable from the political objective, generally more implicit, of control of populations.”

This way of framing the problem did not rule out the possibility that rural populations can benefit from state initiatives in the rural areas, as they might from a rural development program, for example. What this framing implies is that economic or social benefits that may accrue to local populations do so largely as by-products of broader political competitions in which rulers seek to assure their own political survival. It suggests that a full explanation of institution-building initiatives must take account rulers' attempts to entrench their advantage vis-à-vis challengers and potential challengers and to ally with those who can help shore up their power.

Saying that all African regimes pursue similar ends in engagements with rural society—as Bates and le Meur put it, they seek to tax and govern the rural areas—allows for a shift in focus to variation in the strategies they pursue. How do strategies vary? Why do they vary? Consider the first question first. Analysts have noticed differences in the degree of centralization of rural political and administrative structures,² and some have drawn our attention to

2. Most recently, Miles (1994).

differences in regimes' willingness to accommodate (or to confront) established rural elites.³ The degree of interventionism ("statism") of state structures and processes in the rural areas is another variable: Some regimes have been more hands-off or market oriented than others.⁴ Existing work reveals that there has been important variation in the extent, structure, and functioning of state institutions in the countryside. What is missing is an attempt to capture these variations in a general descriptive schema. Here I propose one, operationalized in terms of the kinds of institutional distinctions that figure prominently in the public administration literature.

Following J. Cohen and Peterson (1996, 1997) I will compare institutions linking core and periphery along two dimensions. The first is a spatial dimension: It has to do with how state agencies and institutions are arranged within the national space. The other is processural: It has to do with *de facto* distributions of authority between central and local actors.

The spatial dimension of institutional variation is understood in terms of concentration and deconcentration of the governmental apparatus.⁵ Are localities administered from agencies based in the capital city or from rural outposts of the state? Where there is spatial concentration of the state apparatus, links in the administrative chain that connect core and periphery are few; state agents govern from the center rather than from the localities; and the presence of the state in the localities is minimal. By contrast, where there is spatial deconcentration of the state apparatus, state intervention in local affairs was more immediate, palpable, and intense. State institutions (such as village cells of the ruling party or state-run producer cooperatives) and state agents intervene directly, in many different ways, in local political economies.

The second dimension of variation is processural. J. Cohen and Peterson (1997, pp. 5, 21) call this "the roles and authority" dimension. It measures *de facto* devolution of political authority. In this analysis, we are interested in the distribution of power and prerogative between central regimes and local political authorities. At one end of the continuum the central regime monopolizes roles and authority; there is no devolution of authority. (In other words, authority is centralized.) The regime aims at enhancing the power, prerogatives, and resources of direct agents of the state. At the opposite end of the continuum, agents of the center establish partnerships and brokerage relations with nonstate authorities in the rural areas. In these cases there is a

3. See Mamdani (1996).

4. There is a large literature. This is a theme in the literature contrasting development strategies in Kenya and Tanzania, for example.

5. We look for both horizontal and vertical de/concentration of the state apparatus.

“sharing of roles” via various forms of devolution of authority and discretion.⁶ Devolution reinforces the political, administrative, and even economic prerogatives of local-level notables. This continuum describes variation in the extent to which regimes relied upon established rural power holders to exercise de facto administrative prerogative and political authority in localities.

Institution-building strategies can thus be defined in terms of two separate dimensions: One measures spatial concentration/deconcentration of the state apparatus; the other gauges centralization/devolution of political and economic authority. Working deductively, we come up with a set of four possible institution-building strategies, or possible institutional outcomes:

- (A) Deconcentrated institutional structure; devolved authority. There is a dense network of state and party-state institutions in the rural areas. It provides the infrastructure for de facto or de jure devolution of control over state resources and state prerogatives to rural elites. This provides institutional infrastructure for power sharing. Institution-building Strategy A is *powersharing*.
- (B) Deconcentrated institutional structure; centralized authority. There is a dense network of state institutions in the countryside. It provides infrastructure for state agents (not rural elites) to micromanage local political process. This is a strategy aimed at disruption of established local political process, and displacement of established rural authorities. Strategy B is *usurpation*.
- (C) Concentrated institutional structure; centralized authority. State institutions seem suspended “balloon-like” over the rural localities. State agents govern the localities from a few strategic outposts and act with autonomy from local influences. In Strategy C, the positions of state agents in the rural areas resemble those of a foreign occupying army. This strategy, then, is called *administrative occupation*.
- (D) Concentrated institutional structure; devolution of authority. State institutions seem suspended “balloon-like” over the rural localities, but in contrast to Strategy C, state agents do *not* seek to exercise authority in the local arena. The regime seems to abdicate authority: Localities are left to their own devices. The state seeks to neither engage nor impose. Strategy D is *nonincorporation*.

Now consider the “why” question. If we assume that all regimes seek to tax and control rural populations, then why would a regime choose one strategy over another? Why do institution-building strategies vary?

6. J. Cohen and Peterson (1997, pp. 5, 21). For them, the essence of delegation is discretion. In this study, I take the delegating discretion to be a means of devolving authority. As Binder (1978) argued in an analysis of relations between governmental and traditional authorities in Egypt, discretion is the key resource that local authorities seek to capture and retain.

Following Levi (1988) and Hechter and Brustein (1980), I argue that state-building strategies differ because rulers face different rural challenges and opportunities—rulers operate within different structural or strategic contexts. The proposition is not so far-fetched. It is consistent with the basic logic advanced by Barrington Moore (1966), Robert Brenner (1976, 1982), and Perry Anderson (1974) in explaining variation in European state-building experiences.

II. RURAL INTERESTS AND BARGAINING POWER

There are rich literatures in African history, anthropology, and sociology that trace regional (and sometimes local) variations in rural social organization. Often these variations prove critical in understanding social dynamics in the countryside.⁷ Differences reflect factors such as ecological constraints, indigenous forms of social and economic organization, the uneven impact of colonial rule, differences in the geographic scope and salience of political organizations that preexisted or are external to the modern state (e.g., old states), and the realities of uneven economic development. Land tenure and labor relations are highly diverse. The extent of commercialization of agriculture varies, along with the role and dynamics of land and labor markets. This means that local elites—chiefs, *marabouts*, big planters, big merchants, other notables—have occupied different positions in the social relations of production, appropriated rural surpluses in different ways and degrees, and relied on different social processes to reproduce their local status and power. The argument here is that variations in rural interests, options, and bargaining power influence the nature and stakes of center-local engagement, and hence the institutional strategies that regimes devise in their efforts to govern and tax the countryside.

Macrosociological and macrosociological work on state formation in agrarian societies makes two general propositions about the political effects of variation in rural social organization. The first has to do with the effects of communal structure on rural society's engagement with the state. The second has to do with relations of property and production and how they shape the interests of rural elites.

(a) *Communal structure.* Communal structure consists of the microscopic matrixes of social organization and control that define politics at the local level.⁸ Key variables here are settlement patterns, land tenure and inheritance

7. For starters, Issacman (1990), Furedi (1989).

8. See Hechter (1983, pp. 25, 50), Hechter (1987, p. 10), Taylor (1989), Massey (1994).

regimes, and relations of cooperation, dependency, and coercion in the organization of production. In agrarian society these elements intertwine with the rules and institutions that distribute political power at the local level, govern distribution, and enforce social cohesion. Class structure is an element in the equation, but communal structure does not reduce to this; it can vary across time and space even when class structure, roughly defined, does not. *Peasant*, for example, can be used as a class-analytic term, but peasants can settle in frontier zones where social and political organization above the household level is weak or nonexistent; they can be members of tightly structured or loosely structured village communities; villages can be autonomous or subsumed within larger sociopolitical entities. Variations are associated with differences in the autonomy of rural communities, their capacity for collective action, and the control capacity of locally dominant social groups (Bates, 1981; Levi, 1988; Lichbach, 1995; Moore, 1966; Paige, 1975; Popkin, 1979; Scott, 1976).

Following Hechter (1983, 1987) and Hechter and Brustein (1980), communal structures can be compared across space or time according to the extent to which they concentrate or disperse control over persons and resources.⁹ Concentration—hierarchy, that is—pools control over persons and resources in the hands of a narrow set of actors. Control is a political asset: It creates a rural elite with more clout in dealing with the state than a dispersed set of small asset holders would have.

Work on agrarian politics in other settings provides grounds for the hypothesis that in Africa, hierarchy in agrarian communal structure—as manifest in concentrated control over persons, land, and access to markets—gives rural elites bargaining power vis-à-vis the state.¹⁰ The geographical extent, cohesiveness, and mechanisms for reproducing social hierarchy are the key factors: These define rural leaders' capacity to control the political behavior of the kinsfolk, dependents, subjects, and clients in their domains of influence. The *legitimacy* of communal hierarchy is also a factor in the equation: Legitimate authority lowers the costs of social control (incentives, coercion, enforcement, and monitoring). In a hierarchical peasant society, rural leaders are political actors that the center must engage, either as allies or as rivals.

9. Here I use Hechter to construct a single concept of "hierarchical cohesion." This is really a great simplification, for hierarchy and cohesion are not always the same thing. They could be imagined as two different dimensions of communal structure. Imagine a rural community with a high degree of socioeconomic cohesion. Control over cohesion-enforcing sanctions and incentives could be centralized (hierarchical) or decentralized (e.g., collectively enforced). Thus we have at least three possibilities: absence of cohesion, hierarchical cohesion, and horizontal cohesion. A fuller analysis would investigate each of these. See Boone (in press).

10. For a similar approach, see Magagna (1991).

(b) *Relations of property and production.* If rural elites have political clout, to what ends will it be used? The answer depends largely on their interests, and these are shaped by agrarian property relations.

A key variable is the extent to which rural elites depend on the coercive and legal powers of the central state to control labor and to appropriate their share of the rural surplus. Moore (1966) and Brenner (1976, 1982) argued that where European landed classes depended on the state to shore up labor-repressive modes of agricultural production, collusive relationships between central and local authorities often emerged. Where landholders relied more on markets (or local coercion) to control labor, they often enjoyed more political autonomy vis-à-vis the center. The core of this logic is that economic autonomy heightens the potential for center-local confrontation, whereas rural elites' economic dependency on the state lessens it.

This reasoning, transported to Africa, prompts inquiry into the material bases of different forms of indigenous authority. Political analysis concerned with national-level outcomes systematically downplays distinctions between rural elites who lived off payments from the state, capitalist farmers, rich peasants, landlords who extracted rents from tenants or sharecroppers, indigenous political authorities whose control of land-use rights gave them a hold over sizable peasant populations, farmer-traders, and absentee professional elites. Yet the work of Barrington Moore and Robert Brenner, among others, suggests that the distinctions mattered. In the African context it is demonstrated clearly in the work of Geschiere (1984, 1986) and Furedi (1989), for example. By what rights, claims, laws, or relationships with the state did rural elites gain access to land, labor, and agricultural surpluses? These relations define modes by which rural elites produced or appropriated agricultural wealth and the extent to which they were able to do so without the help of the modern state. What is at issue here, as in the non-African cases, is rural elites' economic autonomy or dependency vis-à-vis the center.

The material foundations of rural privilege tell us something important about rural elites' *interests* in dealing with new regimes. Where rural elites had direct access to sizable rural surpluses, they would be interested in limiting the state's access to it. They were more likely to position themselves as rivals to new regimes or at least to challenge politicians over the division of wealth produced in agriculture. Independent wealth thus gave rural elites an incentive to maintain autonomy from regimes that were interested in broadening the scope of state control over commercializable rural surpluses. Yet how politically threatening would economically independent rural elites be? Did they have the political capacity to challenge the center? This, I argue, would depend more on their capacity to mobilize their followers, dependents, and subjects to their cause. That brings us back to communal structure.

In situations where rural elites did *not* have direct access to the wealth generated in commercial agriculture, their economic privilege and power would be derivative of that of the state. Dependency put them in a subordinate position vis-à-vis the state, and they would have strong incentives to collaborate with the center. How useful would these economically dependent rural elites be as political allies of the center? That would depend on communal structure—that is, it would depend on the amount of influence and control they could exercise over their dependents and followers.

This model does run the risk of overemphasizing the relatively stable and structured aspects of rural social organization. It is true that in rural Africa in the 20th century, communal structures have been extensively manipulated by states, mutated by broader socioeconomic processes, and contested at the grassroots. It would be an equally serious mistake, however, to look at the forces of change or disarray and conclude that local configurations of economic and political authority are or have been completely fluid, or lacking in structure. On the contrary, social inequalities and communal hierarchies in rural Africa have often proven to be broadly rooted and reproducible under changing circumstances.¹¹ This analysis emphasizes continuities in sociopolitical relations at the local level in order to highlight cross-regional variation, and to show that these variations have long-term institutional effects.

III. RURAL DETERMINANTS OF INSTITUTIONAL CHOICE IN WEST AFRICA

Material presented in Parts I and II can be combined into a schematic argument about rural social-structural causes and their institutional effects. It provides hypotheses that are explored in the case studies below and that can be tested and possibly refined through future research.

Where rural notables had political bargaining power afforded by hierarchical communal structure, rulers are expected to undertake intensive state-building efforts at the local level, aimed at harnessing and manipulating local-level power relations. Regimes would pursue strategies aimed at building spatially deconcentrated institutional apparatuses in the rural areas. Anderson (1974) and Hechter and Brustein (1980) linked the parcellized sovereignty associated with feudalism to more deconcentrated state structures.¹²

11. See, for example, Bako-Arifari and Laurent (1998); Blundo (1998), Patterson (1999). For broader brushstrokes, see Bayart (1989), Herbst (2001, pp. 173-180), Widner (1995, pp. 129-154). Consider also Reno (1995).

12. As a consequence of parcellized sovereignty, "functions of the state were disintegrated in a vertical allocation downwards, at each level of which political and economic relations were, on

Here we expect the same relationship: Hierarchical authority in agrarian society produces more layering of the state apparatus and denser networks of state institutions at the local level (that is, deconcentration).

A deconcentrated state apparatus can provide political infrastructure for either power sharing with local elites or for usurpation. We can expect to find power sharing—Strategy A, via devolution of de facto administrative authority within a deconcentrated state apparatus—where rural elites have clout vis-à-vis their subjects but are economically dependent on the state. By contrast, we expect usurpation—Strategy B, via centralization of authority achieved and enforced via a deconcentrated state apparatus—where rural notables accumulate wealth via means that are largely independent of direct state intervention. Ability to accumulate independently would enhance their political autonomy, thereby increasing the potential for direct competition between elites at the center and those on the periphery.

Where hierarchy is absent we have counterfactual situations: There is no rural elite that could threaten the center or deliver much in terms of political benefits that the center would deem useful. The regime will attempt to govern from the center (spatial concentration) rather than building dense networks of state outposts in the rural areas.

We expect to see the strategy of administrative occupation—Strategy C, or spatial concentration of the state apparatus and centralization of authority—in zones that lack a well-defined rural elite but that are deemed strategically (economically, mostly) important to the center. By a strategy of administrative occupation, the center seeks to prevent the emergence of new leaders, prevent local-level political mobilization, and avoid the congealing of political influence at the local level.

Strategy D is nonincorporation, characterized by spatial concentration of the state apparatus and de facto devolution of authority to local actors. In these situations a regime simply forsakes the state-building project in a given region; it relinquishes its option to intervene in local affairs. The strategy is one of neglect or isolation. This seems to emerge where rural societies are not engaged in commercial agriculture and where rural elites lack the clout to help or challenge the center. Because this study focuses on zones of commercial farming, where governments want to tax or to control agricultural surpluses outright (we discuss three zones of peasant-based export crop production), it does not offer a concrete example of Strategy D, the nonincorporation scenario.¹³ However, in West Africa it is easy to know where to look for

the other hand, integrated” (Anderson, 1974, pp. 148-149, as quoted by Hechter & Brustein, 1980, p. 1075).

13. In this analysis, values on both sides of the causal equation have been generated deductively. Here I hope to demonstrate that the expected patterns of relationships are

examples of this: Nonincorporation has been the state-building strategy in many zones that are occupied primarily by nomadic groups.¹⁴

IV. RURAL INTERESTS AND DECENTRALIZATION: 1950s-1980

In the first decades of independence, there was considerable modification, and considerable continuity, in the design of state institutions linking governments to prime export-crop-producing regions. As new African regimes sought to consolidate their power, institutional change was propelled forward by regimes' attempts to politically demobilize the rural masses, coopt or sideline rural elites, and intensify the taxation of export-crop producers. Building and modifying institutions to link state and countryside was a strategy aimed at this end.

Institution-building strategies differed. We see three of the strategies identified above in the main export-producing regions of Senegal, Ghana, and Côte d'Ivoire.¹⁵

Compared along the dimensions identified above, state institutions built in Senegal's groundnut basin could be described as decentralized and deconcentrated (Strategy A). The postcolonial regime built a sprawling state

visible in a subset of cases. A fuller exposition could deal with all the possibilities (see Boone, *in press*).

14. Governments cannot extract much from them (except, of course, their range lands, water rights, and/or their right to exist in peace), often barely try to govern them, and usually offer very little or nothing in terms of social infrastructure.

15. Data for this study were gathered from the author's comparative study of rural marketing circuits in Senegal and Côte d'Ivoire and a wide variety of primary and secondary sources on the countries concerned for the period 1930-2000. Sources included local-level studies of rural administration, development administration, politics, migration patterns, and land tenure use that have been produced over time by anthropologists, geographers, political scientists, agricultural economists, historians, aid-agency monitoring teams, and so forth. Most of this work is place- and time-specific; one contribution of the present research is to bring hitherto unconnected material together into a focused analytic framework. To code cases on the dependent variable, I established criteria by which descriptive empirical material could be taken as evidence for "devolution" of authority to indigenous local authorities or its opposite and measured the degree of spatial deconcentration of the state apparatus by comparing the facts of a local case to our most extreme case of deconcentration, which was Senegal's groundnut basin in the mid-1970s. Similarly, in constructing values on the independent variable, I used local-level studies, mostly by anthropologists, historians, economists, and geographers, to gather information on the nature of sources of rural authority. The three cases presented here are developed more fully in Boone (1995a, 1995b, *in press*). The analytic framework is extended to the cases of Lower Casamance, the Senegal River Valley, the Korhogo region of northern Côte d'Ivoire, and northern Ghana in Boone (*in press*).

apparatus in this part of the country. In the Wolof groundnut basin the central government allowed and encouraged indigenous rural authorities to capture and colonize nearly all rural outposts of the state. Local authorities, in turn, used the state resources so captured to shore up their own local prestige and authority (and wealth). In southern Côte d'Ivoire, the regime of Houphouët Boigny built state institutions that were centralized and concentrated. Indigenous rural authorities were ignored. There were few local-level points of access to state power and resources (Strategy C). In the Asante region of southern Ghana, the Nkrumah regime built an administrative apparatus that was centralized and deconcentrated. An extensive and powerful state apparatus in the rural areas was staffed by agents deployed from the center (Strategy B). The regime attempted to "rewire the circuits of local authority" and undermine the established rural elite.

By the argument advanced above, contrasts in the design of rural institutions can be traced in large part to the fact that postcolonial regimes in Senegal, Côte d'Ivoire, and Ghana confronted very different political challenges and opportunities in their efforts to subordinate and tax peasantries. Variation in rural social organization produced significant differences in the interests of agrarian communities and rural elites and in their capacity to resist rulers' efforts to intensify the tax burden on peasant producers.

In Senegal's Wolof groundnut basin there was a rural elite that exercised a great deal of spiritual and material control over local communities. However, to appropriate its share of the rural surplus, this elite depended on the intermediation of the state. From the midcolonial period on, land grants, loans for agricultural equipment and inputs, resources skimmed from agricultural development programs and the groundnut marketing board, and, most important, steady flows of large cash grants from the state were all necessary to sustain the worldly magnificence and large religious followings of the rural elite. My argument is that these structural features of rural society in the Wolof groundnut basin—strong hierarchy and the dependency of the elite on the state—were necessary conditions for the emergence of a postcolonial power sharing system in which the regime ruled the rural areas "indirectly," relying upon the rural religious elite as its agents. This power sharing arrangement was institutionalized in a sprawling administrative apparatus colonized by the rural elite.¹⁶

In southern Côte d'Ivoire, indigenous rural authorities were extremely weak, both politically and economically. So-called segmentary societies (i.e., societies without centralized political authority) lived in the southwest. In the southeast, commodity production and colonial rule developed in a way

16. There is an excellent literature on politics in central Senegal during the 1950-1980 period. See Copans (1988), Coulon (1981), Cruise O'Brien (1975), Schumacher (1975).

that weakened community coherence and eroded the political and economic hold of indigenous political authorities. Land pioneering across the entire south created rural communities that were new, ethnically heterogeneous, and marked by low levels of social cohesion. These features of agrarian social structure go far in explaining the political weakness of not only indigenous rural elites but of peasant society in general in southern Côte d'Ivoire. Structural attributes of rural society are key to explaining the logic of the institution-building strategy employed by the postcolonial regime of Houphouët Boigny. The institution-building strategy that guaranteed the power of the regime was one that *avoided* the creation of local-level points of access to state power and resources. Thus the state maintained only the most minimal administrative presence at the local level and provided no institutional footholds or political resources that could have promoted the emergence of new, postcolonial generations of rural leaders. As others have observed, southern Côte d'Ivoire was run by a military-style administrative corps controlled directly from the center; no political elite grounded in local politics and in well-structured local constituencies has ever emerged.¹⁷

In southern Ghana, Nkrumah faced direct challenge to his rule from a politically and economically powerful rural elite. As merchants, planters, truckers, moneylenders, and landlords, the aristocrats and planter chiefs centered in Ashanti appropriated their share of Ghana's cocoa wealth directly. They contested directly the regime's attempt to intensify the taxation of export-crop producers. In response, the Nkrumah regime built institutions to link state and countryside that were designed to destroy the political power of rural elite and to usurp their economic power. The result in much of southern Ghana was a highly interventionist state apparatus that remained under the tight control of agents deployed by the regime.¹⁸

This brief review of these cases helps to show why state-centered theories of institutional choice are inadequate. If colonial institutional ideology and inheritance determined outcomes, as Miles (1994) has recently argued in what is indeed a very compelling account, then we would expect postcolonial rural institutions in the main export-producing regions of Senegal and Côte d'Ivoire to look very much the same. Yet by the descriptive schema proposed here, these cases are diametrically opposed: Regimes' institutional choices in central Senegal and southern Côte d'Ivoire differ dramatically, even though the two countries share the legacy of French-style colonialism. And if regime ideology (socialism or its absence) were determinant, as Mamdani (1996) seems to suggest, then we would expect more similarity between the institu-

17. See Bakary (1986, 1991), Chauveau and Dozon (1987), M. Cohen (1973), Crook (1991).

18. The single best work on this is Beckman (1976). See also Mikell (1989a, 1989b).

tional choices of postcolonial socialist regimes in Senegal and Ghana. As it turns out, outcomes in the main export-producing regions could not be more different, especially if measured by the design and functioning of institutions that distributed power between center and locality. The observed variations do not conform to the predictions of these state-centered theories.

What we do see is that in designing and redesigning state institutions, rulers attempted to coopt, demobilize, usurp, bypass, or modify the forms of social power and authority they confronted on the ground. When new African governments confronted rural elites they could coopt and subordinate, they did so, harnessing nonstate forms of authority to that of the state. When regimes confronted local-level elites they could not coopt or subordinate, they sought to undermine the positions of the rural elites and to usurp control over the wellsprings of their authority. The results of these processes were institutionalized in bureaucratic, administrative, and political structures and practices that link states and rural societies.

V. DECENTRALIZATION IN THE 1990s

Similar logics have been driving the politics of institutional reforms in the African countryside since the mid-1980s. The recent phase of state building has taken place in an international and economic context very different from the postindependence phase of the 1960s and 1970s. Profound fiscal crisis of the state and economic liberalization have meant the dismantling of some of the institutional linkages between states, rural elites, and peasants that structured rural governance in the earlier period.

Shrinking of the state has not, however, produced "politically unstructured" local arenas. On the contrary, in politically and economically strategic rural zones, rural administration remains in place, as do the political machines built to ensure rural electoral turnout during the era of one-party rule. Where political liberalization has intensified interparty competition at the national level, we see a reinvigoration of the politics of constituency building in many rural districts. Many regimes, including those studied here, have made new investments in institutional machinery for mobilizing and organizing the rural vote.

Meanwhile, political society at the local level is structured by informal institutions that define community hierarchy, cohesion, and control over access to local resources and to the state. In much of rural Africa, access to some key economic resources, adjudication of ordinary civil disputes, and brokering relations with national-level politicians and state agents remains in the hands of local notables. As Mamdani insisted, "big men" of one sort or

another still wield prerogative and power over the lives of most ordinary people. Dynamic factors in the equation are precisely how economic changes and the rollback of some state functions affect established forms of local power and privilege and whether established authority is thereby reinforced, or subject to new challenge. It is clear that the cast of characters constituting the local-level elite has broadened since the 1970s and that education, position in the state itself, and pure financial prowess are more common (and even more legitimate) sources of local clout and influence than they were in the earlier period.¹⁹ However, given some probing, it nearly always becomes apparent that new local elites usually navigate within contexts structured by older patterns of communal hierarchy and authority (or the absence thereof).

The new wave of political and administrative decentralization in the late 1980s and 1990s created the appearance of disjuncture with earlier patterns of rural institutional development. The sense of rupture was amplified by simultaneous moves to liberalize rural commerce and marketize the export trade. Yet even a quick look at decentralization politics in the Wolof groundnut basin, southern Cote d'Ivoire, and southern Ghana reveals that there are striking continuities in patterns of institutional development within each region over the *entire* post-1960 period. By the argument advanced in this article, the historical continuities are traceable to underlying power configurations in rural society (yes, they have changed, but surprisingly often they bear a strong resemblance to earlier forms) and to the attempts of regimes to manipulate these to their own advantage. Thus we find that the cross-regional differences in institutional structure and process that marked the 1950s-1970s are also observable in the current period.

There are many detailed local studies of the decentralization reforms that have been underway in Senegal since the mid-1980s. Most of them concentrate on the politically strategic Wolof groundnut basin, where state controls over the groundnut economy were dismantled in the 1980s and early 1990s and where the administrative, political, and land-use prerogatives of elected rural councils and municipal government have gradually expanded.²⁰ These studies reveal strong continuities with the earlier era of rural politics and administration in central Senegal. Contemporary analysts emphasize the domination of decentralized institutions by the groundnut basin's long-standing rural elite and the processes by which these local notables have captured control of the resources and prerogatives so distributed. Even with deterioration of the regime's capacity to pump cash into rural outposts of the state,

19. See, for example, Berry (1985).

20. (Agrawal & Ribot, 1999; Beck, 1998, 2001; Blundo, 1998; Dione, 1992; Diop & Diouf, 1992, p. 86; Niang, 1991; Patterson, 1999; Ribot, 1999; Vengroff 1993). See also Villalon (1994).

local government and party institutions still function as purveyors of central resources and as sites that local elites capture to consolidate their personal clienteles and constituencies. Notables work to sustain some measure of legitimate authority by ensuring that some benefits trickle down to ordinary rural folk. Meanwhile, Senegal's ruling politicians continue to rely on rural strongholds to assure election victories. The institution-building strategy of power sharing (Strategy A) still produces political payoffs for the regime in Dakar.

In Senegal, economic liberalization and the general decline of the agricultural export economy have promoted decay of some of the formal and informal institutions that structured relations between the peasants, the rural elite, and the state in the earlier period. Rural notables such as the Mouride marabouts no longer derive personal profit and political resources from their control over groundnut cooperatives (which were dissolved in 1984). As the old groundnut economy had declined, the old land-based ties between marabouts and their followers have eroded. The increasing competitiveness of rural politics in central Senegal is partly a result of these changes. Yet change has not been revolutionary: The kinds of community-level power relations that structured rural government and administration in the 1960-1980 period are still very much in evidence. Local electoral competition, for example, usually revolves around rival factions within the established elite (just as it did from the 1940s to the 1980s) rather than populist or popular challenges to the old aristocratic and religious leaders. As Mamadou Niang (1991) wrote in the early 1990s, decentralization and "disengagement of the state" should not have been expected to change the power structure of central Senegal: Possibilities for real reform have been constrained by "the power of notables in the extremely stratified and hierarchical social system which is the peasant's universe. . . . These notables mediate relations between the state and the peasantry" (pp. 8-9).

In southern Côte d'Ivoire decentralization politics in the 1990s fit squarely into the center-periphery mold established in the 1960-1980 period. As Diahou (1990), Bakary (1986), Fauré (1993), and Crook and Manor (1998) have observed, the decentralization initiatives of the 1990s were reform in name only, for virtually nothing by way of resources or administrative prerogative has been devolved to newly created municipal governments and the councils elected to run them. These organs are marked by a lack of connection to, or communication with, local constituencies. In the Ivoirian south, local government remains under the control of Abidjan-based politicians and administrators whose power derives from the center, rather than from the support or allegiance of local populations. Abidjan governs via a

top-down process; in the south, localities do not “throw up” leaders who are then coopted into the institutions and political processes of the regime.

Centralization of authority and spatial concentration of the state apparatus produced a virtual administrative occupation of the Ivorian south in the earlier period (Strategy C). Houphouët refused to create resource-purveying institutions at the local level that could be captured and used by would-be political entrepreneurs. This strategy was sustained after 1990. The weakness of communal institutions in southern Côte d’Ivoire is what has made such an institution-building strategy politically possible. Social fragmentation, economic atomization of households, unstable economic relations among factions in ethnically heterogeneous villages, and the narrow scope of all forms of local political authority are enduring features of society in the forest belt. Houphouët’s strategies of rural governance and export crop surely reinforced and accentuated this local reality. The facts on the ground thus help explain the institution-building strategies we have seen in southern Côte d’Ivoire and are useful in understanding how and why decentralization outcomes in this case differed so significantly from those observed in central Senegal.

The particular vulnerabilities of rural society in southern Côte d’Ivoire were much in evidence during the Bédié regime. Politicians competed by making direct ethnic appeals to rural voters whose sporadic mobilizations proved difficult to control or channel, given the absence of politically coherent local communities and rural notables who could have organized local politics and served as intermediaries for Abidjan-based politicians. Outbreaks of ethnic violence, violent land conflicts within villages, and mob justice in the core export-producing zones of the southwest were manifestations of the problem. The state in southern Côte d’Ivoire is “suspended above” politically unstable rural societies, and the so-called decentralizations of the 1990s have helped to reproduce this result.

From about 1970 to the early 1980s, Ghana endured a virtual collapse of the cocoa-export economy and the extensive decay of the state’s rural institutional infrastructure.²¹ The Rawlings regime undertook to rebuild the “local state” and rural economy in southern Ghana in the 1980s and 1990s. The politics of institutional choice have been remarkably similar to what was observed during the Nkrumah period. Rawlings has pursued a strategy aimed at consolidating a populist rural support base for the regime. By institutionalizing this constituency base, the regime hopes to bypass the old, partisan, rural elite in the south and to offset the weight of its urban rivals, middle-class detractors, and Ashanti-based opponents (Green, 1998).

21. See Beckman (1981, pp. 151-2) on the old cooperatives and on the licensing of private cocoa buyers under the National Liberation Council (1966-1969) and the Busia government (1969-1972).

In the rural areas of the south, Rawlings has created peoples committees, Committees for the Defense of the Revolution (CDRs), and district assemblies to run local government.²² In organizing local government, the regime sought to sideline the old partisan elite and bring “a whole new group of average citizens” to power (Green 1998, p. 198). To a large extent, this is what has happened: Many teachers and ordinary farmers have been elected to seats in Ghana’s new district assemblies. Devolution of power to localized instances of this newly deconcentrated party-state apparatus remains very limited, however. The institution-building strategy is Strategy B, described above as usurpation. The CDRs and other rural youth brigades remained under tight central control, while in each district assembly one third of all seats are filled by individuals appointed by Accra (as had been the case in the rural assemblies under Nkrumah). The regime retains a firm grip on what Green calls the local state.

Attempts to consolidate and institutionalize a populist rural base served Rawlings well in the 1992 and 1996 elections. Ashanti was the only region of the country outside of Accra to deliver a majority vote against the regime.

The divide between Ashanti and the ruling Provisional National Defense Council (PNDC) has usually been cast as ethnic rivalry. Following the reasoning laid out above, our attention is drawn to the fact that there are long-standing economic and social-structural sources of tension between the regime and the rural elite in Ghana’s cocoa belt. The Kumasi elite along with ordinary farmers in the cocoa belt benefited disproportionately from Ghana’s post-1983 economic reforms and economic upturn. As Herbst (1993, pp. 86–88) reported, the Kumasi elite resented the transfer of wealth out of their region to fund state spending in other parts of the country. Not only did their long-standing economic grievances with the center carry over into the 1990s, but so too did some of their capacity to politically organize rural constituencies and to back candidates for the highest levels of national office. The seismic fault that had divided Nkrumah from the cocoa farmers of Ashanti still remained active in the Rawlings era.²³ In his analysis of the electoral contexts of the 1990s, Nugent (1999) depicts the battle between the Rawlings regime and the “Ashanti notables and big wigs” as quite stark in Ghana’s cocoa-producing core—Ashanti and the eastern region. This political struggle helps to explain why and how the Rawlings regime pursued institutional reform in the rural areas of southern Ghana.

22. See Herbst (1993, p. 84), who said that in 1989, “most of the organizations that the Rawlings government [had] attempted to establish in the rural areas [were] disorganized and ineffective.” See also Crook and Manor (1998), Green (1998), and Mikell (1989a).

23. See Nugent (1999).

Crook and Sverrisson (1999) provide some support for this reading of center-local politics under Rawlings. They note a general tension between the existing rural elite on the one hand, and local-level actors promoted by Rawlings' state-building initiatives on the other. Crook and Sverrisson observe that where local leaders "such as the chiefs and the wealthy, professional often absentee elites (successful sons and daughters of the town)" are influential and active in well-established community development associations, local constituents defer to them and are less willing to go along with the state-building initiatives of the regime. Where the local elite is active and respected, local constituents are "less willing to pay [District] Assembly taxes or accord any legitimacy or usefulness to [District Assembly] activities."²⁴ To read the Rawlings strategy as the politics of usurpation may be somewhat overdrawn, but something that hints of this dynamic (Strategy B) seems to be at work.

Crook and Manor (1998), Green (1998), and Herbst (1993) write that the rural institutions created by the Rawlings regime were intensely politicized. The regime's efforts to create a local state and ensure top-down control over it, and to use state resources to build a rural political machine to support the ruling party, worked to short-circuit the democratic potential of political and administrative decentralization.

Rawlings's strategy was quite different from the power sharing strategy pursued by the Diouf regime in the Wolof groundnut basin of Senegal in the 1980s and 1990s. It also differed from the strategy of administrative occupation chosen by the Ivoirian regime in the southern forest belt in the 1990s.

In their broad outlines these outcomes, the observed historical continuities, and the cross-case differences conform to expectations generated by the hypotheses presented in Part III. There is surely a great deal more to say about each case and the cross-case comparisons. The point here is that there appears to be a logic of political choice that is played out across time and that is partly explainable in terms of the interests and political clout of rural actors.

Conclusion

In writings sponsored by North American and international development agencies, and in the work of some prominent African and American scholars and public intellectuals, a leading rationale for institutional decentralization

24. Crook and Sverrisson (1999, p. 45). It seems that Brong Ahafo in the 1980s was an exception. Here Rawlings seemed to play Nkrumah-style regional geopolitics by cultivating alliances with "traditional notables." See Mikell (1989b, pp. 470, 473).

has been that it promotes local political participation and harnesses grass-roots forms of democracy. With some hindsight it is perhaps obvious that the democratic decentralization initiatives of the 1980s and 1990s were bound to produce uneven and contradictory results. Often the results have been disappointing. One problem was that the expectations of reform were often not premised on analysis of the rural settings in which reform was carried out. Here I have argued that such an analysis can help to explain why the actual implementation and effects of decentralization initiatives have varied so much across regions and localities and why they have often been so ambiguous in their effects.

What are the lessons of this study for those interested in local-level institutional reform in Africa, and in other settings? One implication is that decentralization remains a strategy that regimes employ (or avoid) in attempts to reinforce their own advantage. Political logic will often trump the economic or welfare-enhancing logic of reform. That said, it can be a mistake to assume that rulers act with autonomy vis-à-vis rural populations, however disenfranchised the rural world may appear. Regimes manipulate local power relations to their own advantage; they try to avoid moves that foment local challenge. Weakness of the state is itself a factor that dictates strategic action, for weak regimes have strong incentives to accommodate local authority when it helps to shore up the center and to subvert local authority (or preempt its emergence) if it can be a challenge.²⁵ Resource flows that are manipulated from above still help the center tip the balance in local competitions for leadership roles and status.

If the cases above are any guide, then we can say that regimes are unlikely to devolve real power and resources to rural leaders they do not trust and/or cannot control. Prospects for real devolution in the contemporary period may be best in places such as central Senegal, where a relatively stable rural elite—an elite that enjoys an important measure of legitimate authority on the local level—is already imbricated in the governing structures and processes of the state.

A second general implication is that rural communities and localities must be understood as political arenas that vary in their structure, hierarchy, cohesion, and capacity for collective action (Agrawal & Ribot, 1999). At the microscopic level, gender, family, lineage, caste, status, landlord-stranger, creditor-debtor, and class relationships can constitute powerful mechanisms of sociopolitical cohesion and control. Meanwhile, most rural communities are connected to national power centers by hierarchically structured political

25. Treisman (2001) focuses on appeasement of powerful regional interests as a strategy of the Yeltsin regime in Russia.

and administrative institutions and by vertically structured relationships that tie local actors to politicians and administrators at the center. Institutional reform thus usually occurs in already structured local settings in the context of preexisting ties between center and periphery. The nature of these relationships shapes the course of reform.

Lastly, we should expect the political topography of center-periphery relations within any given country to be uneven. Rural social formations differ across space, and in any given country, rural societies are almost inevitably tied to the center in different ways. Senegal's regime adopted polar opposite decentralization strategies in the Wolof groundnut basin and in the Lower Casamance. From 1960 to the 1990s, power sharing with rural notables was the pattern in the Wolof groundnut basin; Lower Casamance, by contrast, has been subjected to rigid centralization of power and top-down control over the course of the postcolonial period (reminiscent of southern Côte d'Ivoire; Boone, in press). One implication is that studies of decentralization that focus on one part of a national political unit may not be generalizable to the whole.

One source of variation in decentralization strategies and outcomes is the fact that governments deal with societal challenges and opportunities that vary across space. Many existing explanations of institutional variation, by contrast, are starkly state-centric, and this is especially so in African studies. Thinking seriously about institutional choice in the rural areas as political strategy helps to correct for the state-centric bias in most of the literature. It also suggests new ways of theorizing the social origins of the modern African state.

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